



CoARA Action Plan 2025–2029: Diaconia University of Applied Sciences (Diak)

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Introduction

Diaconia University of Applied Sciences (Diak) is committed to advancing responsible research assessment in line with the principles of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA). As a signatory of the CoARA Agreement, Diak aims to foster a culture of openness, inclusivity, and quality in research and researcher assessment.

This plan sets out our commitment to foster an environment where research, researchers, and those who support them, can thrive. It has five underpinning values – social inclusion, wellbeing, equality, diversity, ethics and integrity and learning. We aim to realise a research lifecycle where research culture, research integrity and fair research assessment are interdependent and mutually reinforcing.

This means that Diak seeks to make its research data, learning materials, and other activities as openly available, discoverable, and usable as possible. Diak's operations are guided by the principle of openness: "As open as possible, as closed as necessary."

Building on previous work within the organisation, various RDI guidelines and tools have already been developed. However, there remains a need for continuous enhancement of evaluation practices and support for the research evaluation culture in alignment with the CoARA agreement. The current action plan identifies development areas aimed at advancing reform in fairness, diversity, inclusion, and transparency. This plan outlines our concrete steps for implementing CoARA commitments from 2025 to 2029.

Our CoARA Action Plan

Our action plan below lists each of the ten CoARA commitments with a summary against each, covering: 1) What we are already doing and/or progress underway, and 2) Our longer-term plans, where we will embed continuous improvement.

The ten CoARA commitments are:

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index
4. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to
5. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes
6. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
7. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

8. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments
9. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

Objectives for Diak CoARA action plan:

1. Integrate CoARA principles into Diak's RDI and researcher assessment processes.
2. Promote open science and responsible research practices across all functions and operations.
3. Support diverse research careers and inclusive evaluation practices.
4. Enhance societal impact through transparent and collaborative research.

Commitment 1: Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research

What we are already doing, and progress underway

We are committed to continuously working towards recognizing the many and varied contributions to research. As well as the diversity of roles that contribute, and the diversity of formats and languages (Finnish and English), we recognize that over the many disciplines in the university of applied science the outputs and outcomes of research can look very different. Recognizing and valuing the variety of research, impact, education and innovation outputs, and the contributions of all staff, students and our partners alike, is core to our approach.

Examples include:

- Learning and development opportunities provided in the university of applied science are not limited to academics. We ensure opportunities are clearly available to all that may benefit. Using Diak's "Map of Disadvantage" website, it is possible to examine the regional distribution of wellbeing and disadvantage at postal code, municipal, and wellbeing services county levels. For this reason, it offers valuable content for research and development projects from the perspective of diversity.
- Diak supports open learning through dialogic change pedagogy, encouraging multiple contributors, including students, researchers, practitioners, to co-create knowledge together.
- We hold an annual International Week to celebrating the diversity- this year 2025 the theme is: A Good World for Everyone – Diversity and Inclusion as Assets.
- Diak's Open Science services with its experts (including the research ethics advisor, library, RDI, learning and publication specialists) are leading on the development of inclusive authorship guidance and associated resources.

Longer-term plans

- Define the goals and evaluation criteria for researcher and expert assessment.
- Evaluate the current HR tools and processes against the defined goals and criteria (such as competence profiles, career path models, recruitment process including anonymous recruiting etc).

- Continue developing HR processes and tools for researcher and expert assessment based on the analyzed needs.
- Advance our research repository and further developing the Map of Disadvantage and Zekki, both grounded in the 3X10D life situation indicator, research evidence, and expert insights.

As part of our continuous improvement approach, in relation to Diak's quality management, we aim to increase engagement from staff and students in our existing activities, while further developing partnership work with strategic partners and sharing good practice across the University of applied science.

Commitment 2: Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators

What we are already doing, and progress underway

We currently have a few practices in place within the University of Applied Sciences, relying on both quantitative and qualitative evaluation as part of a process of continuous improvement. We have an established research permit application and approval process, which includes a research permit notice aimed at openness, a data management plan, and a data protection assessment. However, there are areas where our RDI team, candidates, and assessors need a clearer understanding of how to make the best use of impact measures and to distinguish what constitutes responsible and inappropriate use of metrics; addressing this will be the focus of future work.

Examples include:

- Our evaluations already combine qualitative review (societal relevance, peer review) and quantitative indicators (number of publications, open access visibility).
- The evaluation of Diak's research permit process is based on activities aligned with the strategic objectives and research permits require a data management plan and ethical review.
- Diak has signed the Declaration for Open Science 2025–2030 and is committed to promoting responsible openness. We also follow the good practices for researcher evaluation outlined by the Federation of Finnish Learned Societies (Publication Series 5/2020), the National Recommendation on Responsible Researcher Evaluation.

Longer-term plans

- Develop the evaluation of research and development projects. This includes finalizing and operationalizing the Diak impact management model and aligning tools with CoARA principles.
- Develop resources to ensure that open research and fair practices are recognized and rewarded appropriately. We will do it by fostering a culture of transparency, collaboration, and responsible use of metrics throughout the research lifecycle.

Commitment 3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index

and

Commitment 4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment

What we are already doing, and progress underway

Undertaking research assessment responsibly means assessing the quality of the research undertaken and its outputs directly. Relying on metrics such as a journal impact factor or inferring research quality from the ranking of a researcher's institution isn't responsible in our view. We rely on using peer review and our judgement based on the research itself. We are committed to discontinuing the inappropriate use of journal- and publication-based metrics through continuous improvement, and in tandem with the actions outlined against Commitment 2.

Examples include:

- Diak does not use journal rankings in evaluation; quality is demonstrated through openness, peer review, and impact in society. Decisions related to research ethics and good scientific practice are made nationally by TENK (National Advisory Board on Research Ethics), with Diak serving as an active coalition member.

Longer-term plans

- Diak to adopt a policy by 2025 that prohibits reliance on journal impact factors in recruitment, promotion, or project assessment.
- Communicate this policy in sessions with the personnel and in HR guidance.

Commitment 5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organizational changes committed to

What we are already doing, and progress underway

We have invested in part-time positions and a dedicated team to support the work of defining the objectives for reforming research assessment and the associated organizational change. This work will be carried out in close collaboration with Diak's quality team, enabling more effective use of the overall resources of a small university of applied sciences.

Examples include:

- We have embedded Open science in "Boldly Open Diak" strategy.
- Resources are allocated for publication platforms (Diak Research, Theseus, Dialogi) and open science coordination.
- We have established a working group to outline our approach and to define responsible milestones as part of our commitment to CoARA. This committee was drawn from both RDI, HR, academic and professional services staff.

Longer-term plans

- Review training and research staff induction processes and materials to increase awareness and appropriate use of open and fair research practices, increasing the availability of non-traditional research outputs.
- Ensure resources to pilot and embed the impact management model.

Commitment 6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes

What we are already doing, and progress underway

We are undertaking and engaged in discussions on reviewing, developing and sharing research assessment criteria, tools and processes. These relate to our own processes to assess individual

contributions, and to national and international assessments. Where our local processes are reviewed or evaluated, we will continue to draw input from across Diak.

Examples include:

- In line with the principle of continuous improvement, Diak is updating its comprehensive Project Guide, which serves as a tool and checklist for all those responsible for project and research work, those involved in projects, and those introducing new staff to project practices. The themes covered in the guide, such as project communication, data protection, document management, and research collaboration agreements, also provide a foundation for further developing our assessment criteria, tools, and processes.
- Tools for achieving responsible research assessment criteria include the AOE.fi and Opin.fi services, which promote openness, accessibility, and continuous competence development.
- We have DMPTuuli (Data Management Plan Tuuli), a national online tool for creating data management plans, which we are continuously developing further together with its accompanying guidelines to support open science, research ethics, and funders' requirements.
- We are a user of the Justus - Publication Information Reporting Service, which is used for entering publication data into service. The information saved in JUSTUS is also available through the Research.fi service, which compiles and presents information about Finnish research.
- Diak adheres to national guidelines outlined by TENK and continues to refine assessment practices and criteria for researchers at all career stages.

Longer-term plans

- Develop the project assessment tools and practices further against impact and inclusion indicators.
- Continue to use staff and student surveys to understand the perceptions of research assessment by our community.
- Continue to engage with national and international discussions on review and developing research assessment processes

Commitment 7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use

What we are already doing / progress underway

Diak recognises that transitioning to more inclusive research assessment practices may present challenges, such as balancing qualitative and quantitative approaches in a way that is both fair and feasible, and avoiding overreliance on traditional indicators that do not capture the full diversity of contributions. These challenges will be addressed through ongoing dialogue with the university community and targeted training for evaluators and stakeholders.

Examples include:

- Diak provides staff with guidance on open publishing and data management, supporting transparent and responsible research practices.
- This commitment to openness is recognised nationally, and Diak has performed well in the AVOTT monitoring in 2024.

- Research outputs are widely disseminated through platforms such as Theseus and Dialogi, ensuring accessibility and visibility of Diak's work.

Longer-term plans

- Run an internal communication campaign on CoARA principles.
- Embed CoARA principles in internal communication.
- Organize training sessions on responsible assessment and open science to personnel, supervisors, management.

Commitment 8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition

What we are already doing / progress underway

Diak will continue its strong tradition of collaboration with other Finnish higher education institutions and universities to share knowledge and strategies for overcoming these challenges. Diak also actively participates in key networks, including the Finnish National Board on Research Integrity (TENK) and in the future CoARA. We are engaged in the exchange of practice and sharing research assessment criteria and processes to assess individual contributions in both national and international contexts.

These knowledge-sharing activities often take place within the networks of Diak's RDI projects, where research data plays a central role. Individual staff members' own research networks also serve as platforms for co-development. As a result, knowledge is not always evenly distributed, and this is an area where Diak aims to further improve.

Examples include:

- Diak monitors and reports open science practices via AVOTT framework.
- Diak disseminates outputs via open repositories and professional platforms.
- Diak participates in the nationwide Digivisio 2030 network, which openly shares information related to research activities and their assessment across both universities of applied sciences and traditional research universities.

Longer-term plans

- Continue to actively participate in national networks and their development, particularly regarding the advancement of RDI activities and research assessment.
- Continue to participate in national and international CoARA networks.

Commitment 9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments

What we are already doing / progress underway

At Diak, continuous improvement is a core process and way of working for ensuring quality and learning. Continuous learning is also applied to performing against the CoARA commitments. Diak will continue its strong tradition of collaboration with other Finnish higher education institutions and universities to communicate progress made towards implementing the Commitments and to learn from other organizations. We will continue to communicate progress on our CoARA commitments transparently through semi-annual updates, following the work packages set out in our main plan. Where other action

plans contribute to the advancement of CoARA commitments, progress will be reported through Diak's other public reporting channels.

Examples include:

- Sharing our Action Plan progress publicly with updates.

Longer-term plans

- Add a dedicated webpage to our renewed website, focusing on Responsible Research Assessment and reporting on progress against our commitments.
- Continue to actively participate in national networks and their development, particularly regarding the advancement of RDI activities and research assessment.
- Continue to participate in national and international CoARA networks.

Commitment 10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

What we are already doing / progress underway

There are already well-established processes of continuous improvement at Diak for evaluating and improving the organization's processes. However, there is a need to improve more systematic data collection and especially build new processes on evaluation of process developments against CoARA related development. We are committed to evaluating progress to ensure we are achieving the change we want to see, both at the level of individual interventions and across the whole university of applied science, including the stakeholders with whom we conduct research.

Examples include:

- Research evaluation practices and processes are currently monitored and evaluated as part of RDI project practices and in accordance with the guidelines for good scientific practice (HTK).

Longer-term plans

- Develop benchmarking practices with our partner universities of applied sciences to compare research assessment tools and processes and share the findings openly.
- Engage, where possible and appropriate, in research on research activity led by other milestones.
- Integrate CoARA development into the continuous improvement process.

Work Packages and Actions

WP1: Developing researcher and expert assessment

Action	Description	Timeline	Responsible
1.1	Define the goals and evaluation criteria for researcher and expert assessment.	2025	RDI Unit & HR

1.2	Evaluate the current HR tools and processes against the defined goals and criteria (such as competence profiles, career path models, recruitment process etc).	2026	RDI Unit & HR
1.3	Develop the HR processes and tools for researcher and expert assessment based on the analyzed needs	2006 - 2027	RDI Unit & HR
1.4.	Refine a policy that prohibits reliance on journal impact factors in recruitment, promotion, or project assessment. Communicate policy internally and in HR guidance.	2006	RDI Unit & HR

WP2: Developing the evaluation of research and development projects

Action	Description	Timeline	Responsible
2.1	Finalize the Diak impact management model for RDI	2025	RDI
2.2	Pilot and operationalize the Diak impact management model for RDI	2026-2027	RDI
2.3.	Review the project assessment tools and practices against the CoARA principles	2026	RDI
2.3	Develop the project assessment tools and practices based on the analyzed needs	2026-2027	RDI

WP3: Communication, Training, and Networking

Action	Description	Timeline	Responsible
3.1	Review training and research staff induction proceses and materials to increase awareness and appropriate use of open and fair research practices, increasing	2026-2027	RDI

	the availability of non-traditional research outputs.		
3.2	Internal communication campaigns on CoARA principles	2026 -2029	Communications & RDI and Diak's Open Science and research working group
3.3	Organize training sessions on responsible assessment and open science to personnel, supervisors, management	2026-2029	HR, RDI and Diak's Open Science and research working group
3.4	Participate in national and international CoARA networks	2025–2029	RDI
3.5	Add a dedicated webpage to our renewed website, focusing on Responsible Research Assessment and reporting on progress against our commitments	2026	Communications & RDI and Diak's open Science and Research working group

Governance and contact

Responsible Person: Director of RDI, Diak

Governance:

Diak CoARA Implementation Team is nominated by Executive team of Diak and Director of RDI presents the progress of CoARA work packages twice a year to the Executive team of Diak.

Working Group:

- Diak CoARA Implementation Team (Head of RDI, Human resources specialist, Quality manager, Head of Communications & marketing, Head of library & information services)
- Diak's Open Science and research working group.

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